

BELLE DE JOUR**Luis Buñuel, 1967**

Spanish director Luis Buñuel's French movie *Belle de Jour* appears on the surface to be a conventional male sexual fantasy in movie form. A bored housewife, played by the ravishingly beautiful Catherine Deneuve, spends her afternoons as a prostitute in a local brothel, indulging all kinds of strange requests—a lady of the day (*de jour*), rather than of the night. In Buñuel's hands, the story becomes a poetic, psychological study in which the sex is never graphic and appears almost incidental. It blends reality and dreams in a hallucinatory and beguiling way that leads toward an ending in which, unexpectedly, the woman and her husband are happy at last.

See also: *The Discreet Charm of the Bourgeoisie* 208–09

ROSEMARY'S BABY**Roman Polanski, 1968**

Roman Polanski's horror movie about satanic possession was filmed with an understated realism, which has the effect of making it more frightening. Rosemary (Mia Farrow) and her husband Guy (John Cassavetes) are portrayed as a convincingly real couple with a typical set of marital issues, before their situation takes a sinister turn. Eschewing the normal conventions of suspense, Polanski gives plenty of hints about what is really happening next door. Ruth Gordon excels as the couple's strange neighbor, and won one of the few Oscars ever to go to a horror movie.

See also: *Chinatown* 216–21

SALESMAN**Albert and David Maysles, 1968**

This fly-on-the-wall documentary follows four traveling salesmen as they peddle illustrated Bibles around suburban New Jersey. The movie is an example of the “direct cinema” movement of documentary making, in which lightweight cameras were used to capture everyday life with a minimum of interference from the filmmakers. The four men appear remarkably unaffected by the presence of the cameras, but the precariousness and quiet desperation of their existence is plain to see. At a motivational meeting, the area manager chillingly points out that he has “eliminated a few men.” The money is out there, he says, and if you can't get it, that's your fault. The movie was made in the late 1960s, but depicts an America that has changed little since the 1950s.

A year later, the Maysles brothers would document a very different world with their movie *Gimme Shelter*, in which they followed the Rolling Stones on tour.

ONCE UPON A TIME IN THE WEST**Sergio Leone, 1968**

This tense, slow-burning Western was a critical and box-office flop on its release but is now recognized as Leone's greatest movie. It is a simple tale of greed and revenge in a small town where the railroad is due to arrive. With Henry Fonda cast against type as a killer and Charles Bronson as the mysterious loner out to get him, the movie revels in the atmosphere and ritual

of the build up to a shoot-out, rather than the shoot-out itself. The music by Ennio Morricone gives an epic quality to long, drawn-out scenes in which almost nothing happens.

KES**Ken Loach, 1969**

Based on Barry Hines's 1968 novel *A Kestrel for a Knave*, *Kes* was the first fiction movie made by British director Ken Loach following a string of raw and powerful docudramas. It tells the story of emotionally neglected and bullied teenager Billy Casper (David Bradley), who finds inspiration in training a kestrel he takes from a nest on a farm. Through the bird, Billy learns to open his eyes to broader horizons. The lyrical realism of the movie and the beautiful shots of the bird in flight help make this a moving, uplifting movie despite its almost inevitable sad ending.

MIDNIGHT COWBOY**John Schlesinger, 1969**

Reverberating to Harry Nilsson's jaunty song *Everybody's Talkin'*, *Midnight Cowboy* is a poignant movie that homes in on the loneliness of the seedy side of life in the city, yet delivers an ultimately upbeat message about the power of relationships. It follows young Texan Joe Buck (Jon Voight) as he arrives in New York determined to make a fortune as a gigolo. Joe's naivety ensures that his seedy encounters come to nothing, and he ends up bonding with consumptive con man Ratso (Dustin Hoffman). When it transpires that Ratso is dying, Joe gives up his ambitions and takes him on a trip to Florida.